



Caregiver Check-In

A brief reset for your capacity, support needs, and next realistic act of care

Check your own capacity and make one realistic support or boundary decision before your reserves run empty.

Caregiver Check-In

Family caregivers, parents, guardians, partners and unpaid helpers

Caregivers need care too

A short pause can help you notice strain before it becomes a crisis. This is not about doing everything perfectly; it is about identifying what matters most, what can wait, and where you need backup.

How to use this tool

Work through the pages in any order. Use a pen, pencil, or digital annotation tool. Keep what helps; leave what does not.

Important

This worksheet cannot replace respite, medical care, or crisis services. Seek immediate professional help if you or the person you support may be unsafe, neglected, abused, or unable to meet essential needs. If there is immediate danger or someone cannot stay safe, contact emergency services now.

Capacity scan

Energy (0-10)

Patience (0-10)

Physical tension (0-10)

Mood (0-10)

Connection / support (0-10)

The biggest demand on me today is...

The smallest supportive action I can take today is...

Capacity scan (continued)

Sort the load

Must happen

Essential today

Can wait

Useful, but not essential today

Can be shared

Someone else can help, rotate, or take over

Not mine alone

Requires a team, professional, or more resources

Ask for help clearly

Specific requests make it easier for people to say yes.

Could you help by ___ on ___?

The most useful support would be...

A boundary I need today: I can ___; I cannot safely ___ without help.

My 5-15 minute break will happen at...

My backup plan

Plan before you are past capacity.

My warning signs

The person or service I can contact

One task I will release or delegate

What I need to make tomorrow more manageable

Sources and use note

This printable tool was designed with general self-care and coping concepts from the sources below. It is educational material, not health care or therapy.

National Institute of Mental Health: Caring for Your Mental Health

Self-care, connection, stress-management framing

<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/topics/caring-for-your-mental-health>

National Institute of Mental Health: So Stressed Out

Journaling, relaxation, mindfulness, sleep, and support concepts

<https://www.nimh.nih.gov/health/publications/so-stressed-out-fact-sheet>

NHS: Breathing exercises for stress

Comfortable, unforced breathing guidance

<https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/self-help/guides-tools-and-activities/breathing-exercises-for-stress/>

WebMD: What Is Box Breathing?

Optional paced-breathing presentation

<https://www.webmd.com/balance/what-is-box-breathing>

WebMD: Quick Stress-Relief Rituals

Sensory grounding context

<https://www.webmd.com/depression/quick-stress-relief-rituals>

American Psychological Association: Stress management tips

Thought, emotion, behavior, and reframing context

<https://www.apa.org/topics/stress/tips>

CASEL: Fundamentals of SEL

Emotion identification and self-management framing

<https://casel.org/fundamentals-of-sel/>

CDC: Information for Family Caregivers

Caregiver capacity, breaks, and support framing

<https://www.cdc.gov/disability-and-health/about/information-for-family-caregivers.html>

Child Mind Institute: How to Help Children Calm Down

Coping-ahead and child-friendly calming support

<https://childmind.org/article/how-to-help-children-calm-down/>

Wikipedia: Mindfulness

Plain-language background only; not clinical authority

<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mindfulness>

Reddit community discussions

User-centered presentation inspiration only; not clinical authority

https://www.reddit.com/r/Anxiety/comments/1ch67c8/making_an_anxiety_tool_box_what_should_i_put_in_it/

YouTube guided box-breathing example

Visual pacing inspiration only; not clinical authority

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=tEmt1Znux58>